

Anthony Black: Opportunity, Efficiency & Impact (2025–26)

Caleb Ramsey

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Executive Framing

This season, Anthony Black has emerged as one of Orlando's most important contributors during a year defined by injuries and unmet preseason expectations. He has grown into a 15+ point-per-game scorer, having on-ball responsibility while still thriving primarily in transition and attacking advantages created by his stars. The jump reflects expanded opportunity paired with an efficiency rebound, showing growth that extends beyond simple volume.

1) Career Snapshot

Table 1: Career progression

season	mpg	pts	fg_percent	3p_percent	2p_percent	ft_percent	rTS_percent
2023-24	16.9	4.6	46.6%	39.4%	51.0%	61.3%	-2.0%
2024-25	24.2	9.4	42.3%	31.8%	47.1%	76.1%	-5.5%
2025-26	31.4	15.8	45.8%	34.3%	53.0%	73.8%	-1.9%

Black's rookie season showed promise. The shooting concerns were evident, but his defensive impact provided early value.

As a sophomore, injuries to Jalen Suggs, Franz Wagner, and Paolo Banchero pushed him into a larger offensive role. The volume increased, but efficiency dipped across the board, reflected in a -5.5% relative true shooting mark.

This season, with a more stable structure, his efficiency has rebounded to -1.9% rTS. He is converting twos at a career-high 53.0% and remains solid at the line, though perimeter consistency remains the swing skill.

2) Role & Skill: Margin Changes (year-to-year)

Table 2: Usage + creation changes by season

season	ast_to	usg_percent	transition_percent	potential_assists
2023-24	1.6	12.7	19.3	2.8
2024-25	1.7	19.6	19.5	6.3
2025-26	1.8	21.9	27.7	6.8

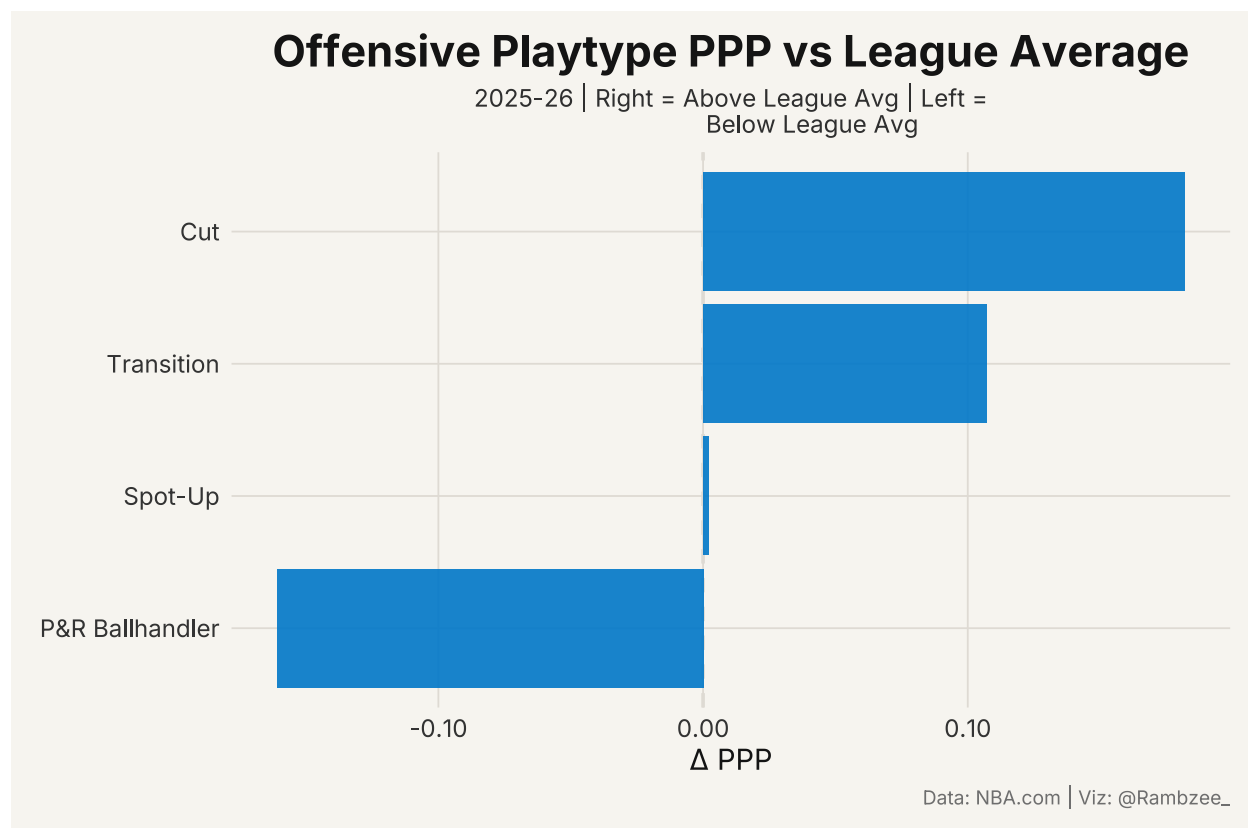
Beyond scoring, the underlying indicators show steady growth. His AST:TO ratio has improved each season from 1.6 to 1.8, even as his usage climbed from 12.7% to 21.9%. Potential assists have more than doubled since his rookie year, reflecting expanded on-ball responsibility without a spike in mistakes.

He has also leaned into his strengths. His transition frequency has jumped to a career-high 27.7%, reinforcing how much of his value is generated in space and advantage situations.

3) Offensive Playtypes: PPP vs League Avg

Table 3: Offensive playtypes (top by volume) + PPP vs league average

Playtype	Poss	Time%	PPP	Lg PPP	Delta PPP	Rating	FGA	FG%	eFG%	TOV%	2FGA	2P%	3FGA	3FGA%
Transition	253	27.7%	1.217	1.11	0.107	Very Good	198	58.6%	62.6%	8.7%	147	68.0%	51	31.4%
Spot-Up	236	25.9%	1.042	1.04	0.002	Good	209	39.2%	53.1%	5.5%	57	42.1%	152	38.2%
P&R Ballhandler	196	21.5%	0.699	0.86	-0.161	Below Average	143	34.3%	38.5%	18.4%	107	34.6%	36	33.3%
Cut	41	4.5%	1.512	1.33	0.182	Excellent	38	73.7%	73.7%	2.4%	38	73.7%	0	0.0%



Black's efficiency is clearly role-driven. He is well above league average in transition and as a cutter, where his speed and instincts allow him to capitalize on space and broken coverage.

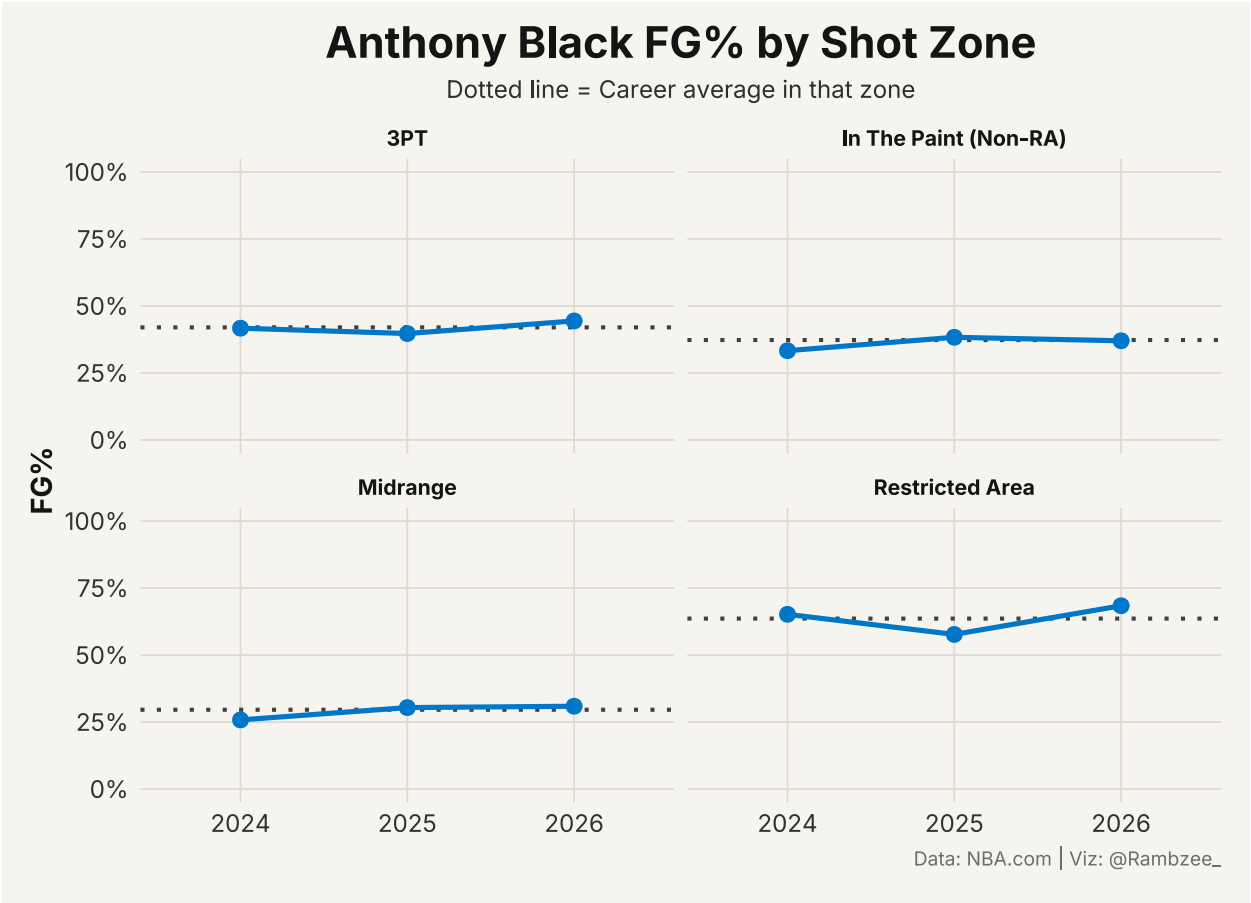
His spot-up value is less about pure shooting and more about attacking closeouts. He remains a subpar overall shooter, but he is serviceable in the corners and capable of keeping defenses honest.

The limiting factor is on-ball creation. At -0.161 relative PPP as a pick-and-roll ballhandler, he struggles to generate efficient offense when asked to initiate.

4) Shot Zones Trend

\begin{table}[!h] \caption{Shot zones (career-high FG% highlighted)} \end{table}

zone	season	fg	fga
ATB Threes	2026	30.0%	190
Corner Threes	2026	44.4%	81
In The Paint (Non-RA)	2026	37.0%	138
Midrange	2026	30.9%	55
Restricted Area	2026	68.4%	234
ATB Threes	2025	26.7%	116
Corner Threes	2025	39.7%	78
In The Paint (Non-RA)	2025	38.3%	154
Midrange	2025	30.4%	56
Restricted Area	2025	57.7%	215
ATB Threes	2024	37.0%	46
Corner Threes	2024	41.7%	48
In The Paint (Non-RA)	2024	33.3%	30
Midrange	2024	25.8%	31
Restricted Area	2024	65.2%	92



The clearest growth is at the rim. He’s finishing 68.4% in the restricted area, a strong jump from last season and above his rookie mark. That tracks with the broader theme that Black is more efficient when attacking space.

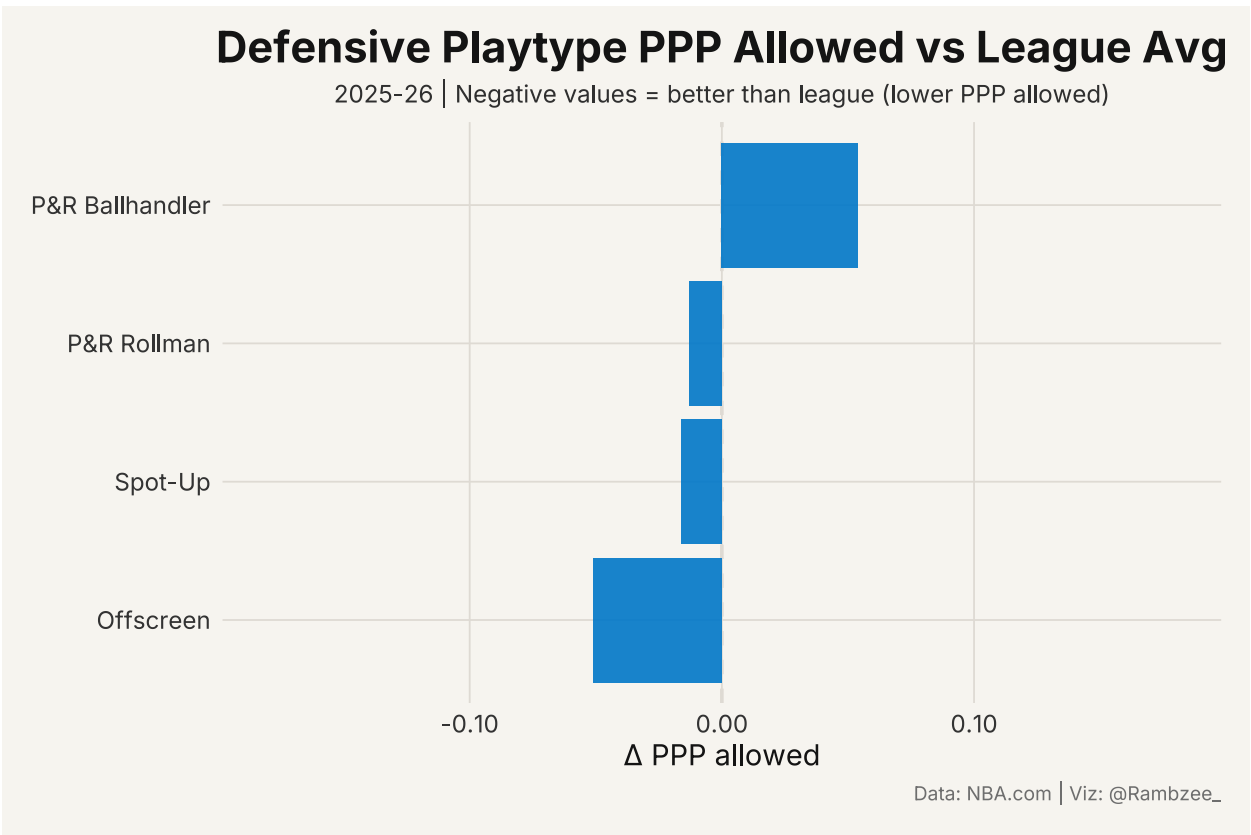
Non-RA paint and midrange are clearly his worst areas. He’s improved from the midrange (25.8% as a rookie to roughly 31% the last two seasons), but it’s still not a weapon.

From three, he’s dependable in the corners at 44.4%, but above the break sits at 30.0%. That contrast reinforces where his shooting currently holds up and where it still lags.

5) Defensive Playtypes: PPP Allowed vs League Avg

Table 4: Defensive playtypes (top by volume) + PPP allowed vs league average

Playtype	Poss	Time%	PPP allowed	Lg PPP	Delta PPP	Rating	Opp FG%	Opp eFG%	Forced TOV%
P&R Ballhandler	337	40.2%	0.914	0.86	0.054	Average	43.8%	49.1%	14.2%
Spot-Up	205	24.5%	1.024	1.04	-0.016	Good	36.8%	49.7%	2.9%
P&R Rollman	63	7.5%	1.127	1.14	-0.013	Good	58.8%	61.8%	9.5%
Offscreen	55	6.6%	0.909	0.96	-0.051	Good	38.0%	47.0%	3.6%



Defensively, most of his workload comes at the point of attack. Against pick-and-roll ballhandlers he’s +0.054 above league average, meaning teams are scoring a bit more efficiently than average in that matchup. Some of that likely comes with the territory, as he often draws primary creators.

His impact shows up more clearly away from the ball. He’s slightly better than league average against spot-ups and roll men and notably strong off-screen at -0.051 ΔPPP. He’s active as a help defender, sharp chasing shooters, and generally disruptive around the action. The toughest on-ball matchups can skew the numbers, but he plays with awareness and sets a defensive tone.

6) Disruption: Deflections

Table 5: Deflections per game leaderboard (top 25)

rank	player	gp	deflections
1	Kelly Oubre Jr.	33	4.3
1	Ausar Thompson	50	4.3
1	Cason Wallace	53	4.3
2	Dyson Daniels	54	4.2
3	Ryan Rollins	51	4.1
4	Kris Dunn	55	3.7
5	Jordan Goodwin	53	3.6
5	Kawhi Leonard	42	3.6
5	Tyrese Maxey	53	3.6
6	Jalen Suggs	34	3.5
6	VJ Edgecombe	51	3.5
6	Reed Sheppard	54	3.5
7	Herb Jones	33	3.4
7	Bilal Coulibaly	34	3.4
7	Nickeil Alexander-Walker	55	3.4
8	Jake LaRavia	54	3.2
8	Scottie Barnes	55	3.2
8	Donte DiVincenzo	56	3.2
9	Dru Smith	54	3.1
9	Anthony Black	54	3.1
9	De'Anthony Melton	30	3.1
10	Alex Caruso	38	3.0

While the efficiency splits are mixed depending on matchup, the disruption is consistent. Black ranks top 10 in the league at 3.1 deflections per game, in the company of Scottie Barnes, De'Anthony Melton, and Alex Caruso, placing him firmly in the high-activity tier.

7) Impact / On-Off

Table 6: On/Off impact (Databallr; low-leverage removed)

minutes	ortg_on	ortg_off	drtg_on	drtg_off	net_on	net_off	off_swing	def_swing	net_swing
1673	116.2	110.8	115.2	113.8	1.1	-3.1	5.5	1.3	4.1

The on-off data, with garbage time removed, ties it together. The team is +1.1 with Black on the floor and -3.1 when he sits, a 4.1-point net swing driven mostly by offense. The defensive swing is smaller and slightly negative on the surface, though lineup context matters, as he often shares top assignments and sits in offense-heavy rotations. He's not a primary engine, but he's a winning player.

Conclusion

- **Role clarity:** His offense is at its best in transition, cuts, and closeout attacks, not as a primary pick-and-roll creator.
- **Finishing growth:** The biggest step is at the rim, with a clear jump in restricted-area efficiency that matches his advantage-based usage.
- **Defensive identity:** Even when the toughest on-ball matchups skew PPP, he consistently impacts possessions with off-ball activity, help reads, and disruption.
- **Winning impact:** The on-off numbers back up what shows up in the data. The team performs better when he's on the floor, and he helps both the offense and defense stay steady.